FIGHTERBASE

Carb cycling

Diet guide

More carbs on hard days, fewer on easy days.



Prepared 10 October 2026 for FighterBase members. Eating styles library, one of a set.

DRAFT: not yet reviewed by a registered dietitian. General information only, not medical advice. Check with your doctor or a registered dietitian before changing how you eat, especially if you have a medical condition, are pregnant, or are under 18.

USING FIGHTERBASE

How to use this diet guide

This diet guide is part of your eating styles library in the FighterBase app. The pages that follow are built to be skimmed. You do not need to read it all at once.

1. **Open Nutrition**
   In the app, open the **Nutrition** tab and tap **Eating styles**.

2. **Tap Carb cycling**
   Read the short summary, what to eat, what to go easy on, and what to watch.

3. **Follow it**
   Tap **Follow this style**. Recipes and the Foods list then filter to match, so you only see what fits. You can follow more than one style.

4. **Download the PDFs**
   Use **Full food list** and **Diet guide** to save these to your phone. Handy for the shop or a restaurant.

5. **Log it and train**
   Meals you log count towards your day. Spend your energy on training, not on reading labels.

> Looking for the full list of foods? Download the **Full food list** PDF from the same screen. It names every allowed and avoided food.

THE BASICS

What is Carb cycling?

Carbs change with the training day: higher on sparring or double-session days, lower on rest days. Combine with any style.

Where it comes from

Carb cycling moves between higher-carb and lower-carb days to match training. It comes from bodybuilding and has spread into combat sports and general fitness. The idea: eat more carbs when you train hard and fewer on rest days.

The main ideas

1. High-carb days match hard or long training.
2. Low-carb days match rest days or light sessions.
3. Protein stays steady on every day.
4. Fat tends to move the opposite way to carbs: more on low-carb days, less on high-carb days.
5. Total food and training matter more than the exact cycle.

Who it suits

- People training on a clear weekly schedule
- People who want to eat more around hard sessions
- People who like structure

Talk to your doctor or a registered dietitian first if:

- You have diabetes or take medication that needs food
- You are pregnant, breastfeeding or under 18
- You have ever had an eating disorder
- You are cutting weight for a fight

TRAINING

Fuel for training

- High-carb days: rice, potatoes, oats, pasta, fruit and bread around hard sparring and conditioning.
- Low-carb days: protein, vegetables and healthy fats, with fewer starchy foods.
- Moderate days sit in between and suit lighter technical sessions.
- Do not drop carbs on days with hard training. That is where performance suffers.

> Plan carbs around the day's hardest session.

Nutrients to keep an eye on

Protein
repair on every day
Where: meat, fish, eggs, dairy, tofu, beans

Carbohydrate
fuel on training days
Where: rice, potatoes, oats, pasta, fruit

Fibre
gut health
Where: vegetables, fruit, beans, whole grains

Fluids and electrolytes
hydration
Where: water, salt, potassium foods

Common mistakes

- Low-carb day before a hard session
- Too many categories and too much tracking
- Using low-carb days as a way of under-eating
- Overcomplicating a simple week

EVERYDAY LIFE

Labels, eating out and swaps

Reading labels

- Carbs per serving matter more than 'sugar'
- Starch hides as maltodextrin, modified starch, flour
- Check sauces and drinks on low-carb days

Eating out

- High-carb day: pasta, rice, potatoes or pizza are fine.
- Low-carb day: grill, salad, vegetables, no bread or chips.
- Plan the week so social meals fall on high-carb days.

Easy swaps

Rice on a low-carb day	→	Cauliflower rice
Pasta on a low-carb day	→	Courgetti
Fruit juice	→	Whole fruit
Bread	→	Extra vegetables

Timing guide

Day type	Carbs	Typical foods
High-carb day (hard sparring, conditioning, long session)	High	Rice, potatoes, oats, pasta, fruit, bread, lean protein, low fat
Moderate day (technical or lighter session)	Medium	Some rice or potato with meals, fruit, vegetables, protein
Low-carb day (rest or very light)	Low	Protein, vegetables, salad, eggs, nuts, olive oil, a little fruit

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

A sample week

One way a week could look. Portions and total food depend on you and your training.

	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	High: oats, banana, eggs	High: chicken, rice, vegetables	High: pasta, lean mince, salad
Tue	Moderate: eggs, toast	Moderate: tuna salad, small potato	Moderate: salmon, vegetables, rice
Wed	High: porridge, fruit	High: wrap, fruit	High: chicken, noodles, vegetables
Thu	Low: omelette, avocado	Low: chicken salad	Low: steak, green beans
Fri	Moderate: yoghurt, berries, granola	Moderate: soup and bread	Moderate: fish, potatoes, greens
Sat	High: pancakes, fruit	High: jacket potato, beans	High: pizza or pasta
Sun	Low: bacon, eggs	Low: salad and cold meats	Low: roast chicken, vegetables

Snacks

Fruit and rice cakes on high-carb days · Nuts and boiled eggs on low-carb days · Greek yoghurt · Jerky

Shopping list

Carb sources: rice, oats, potatoes, pasta, bread, fruit · Protein: meat, fish, eggs, dairy, tofu · Vegetables · Olive oil, nuts, avocado

GOOD TO KNOW

Questions people ask

How many high-carb days?

Match them to your training: often two to four a week.

Does it burn more fat?

There is little strong evidence it beats a steady plan. Its main benefit is fitting food to training.

Is it good before a fight?

Do not try new patterns in fight week. Talk to a professional.

Further reading

British Dietetic Association; sports nutrition reviews; Sports Dietitians UK.

For fighters and combat athletes

- **No eating style makes a rapid weight cut safe.** Sweating, fluid restriction and crash diets hurt performance and can be dangerous. Plan any weight cut with a registered sports dietitian and your coach, well before the weigh-in.
- **Fuel the training first.** Hard sparring and conditioning need carbohydrate and enough total food. If a style cuts a food group, have a plan to replace what is lost.
- **Protein across the day.** A common general range for people training hard is about 1.4 to 2.0 g per kg of body weight a day (draft range, to be confirmed by a dietitian).
- **Try changes in training, never in fight week.** Test new foods, supplements and timing well before competition.
- **Under 18, pregnant, or with a medical condition:** get advice from a doctor or dietitian before changing your diet.

FIGHTERBASE

Train. Eat. Recover. Repeat.

Your eating styles library lives in the Nutrition tab. Pick a style, follow it, and get back to training.

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